

Write Powerful Essay Paragraphs with the PEEL Method

A 3,000-word essay is not an intro, conclusion and then 2,500 words splurged onto a page and roughly split into paragraphs. Your essay needs to be CRAFTED and STRUCTURED. It needs to guide the reader around all your great ideas that you’ve spent so much time on. Your essay needs to be structured so that all your great points stand out and your ideas and arguments are understandable – to tick all those boxes to get you great marks.

Outside your introduction and conclusion, which have their own rules for writing them, you can use the PEEL method, or a variation of it, to structure all of the paragraphs in the main body of your essay.

Each paragraph can be seen as a partial answer to your essay question. Using the PEEL method will then help you to recognise what to include in each of these partial answers so it’s easier to know when to start a new one. Using the PEEL method correctly will also help you proofread your essay as it’ll be easier to spot weaker sections, and it will help you write your conclusion because you’ll have already started your answer with your ‘link back to the question’ sentences.

POINT

The P in PEEL stands for POINT. This means that the first sentence in each of your paragraphs needs to POINT the reader in the right direction. You don’t want the contents of your paragraph to be a surprise to the reader. Instead, you want the first sentence to explain what the paragraph is going to be about. For example, for a business essay about the most effective approach to strategy, a great opening POINT for a paragraph could be...

There are numerous benefits to organisations of taking a bottom-up approach to strategy.

This POINT makes it clear to the reader that this paragraph is going to share a number of benefits of this strategic approach. If the paragraph doesn’t actually do this, you’ll create potential confusion for your reader which will lose you marks for structure AND mean that it’s harder for them to give you marks for your ideas.

EVIDENCE

The next part of PEEL is the first E which stands for EVIDENCE. This part of your paragraph could be two, three or more sentences that provide EVIDENCE for your POINT. One of your jobs as an academic essay writer is to put forward arguments – but these HAVE to be grounded in solid proof from your course or wider reading – theories, concepts, research, examples, statistics. So, this is the part of your paragraph where you give the reader reason to take your ideas seriously, where you make them trust you. You find ideas from your course and include them with accurate referencing to make it clear that you’re not pulling your idea out of your butt.

Let’s return to our example. The POINT was: *There are numerous benefits to organisations of taking*

a *bottom-up approach to strategy*. So there are lots of options for EVIDENCE here. Relevant sentences might include:

- A reference to a study that found that a bottom-up approach to strategy led to higher employee engagement – with a statistic.
- A reference to another study that found innovation was improved for organisations that used a bottom-up approach.

EXPLANATION

It's not enough to just make a POINT and then add in some relevant references. You also have to EXPLAIN what your EVIDENCE means, why the information is valuable and how your points are in any way relevant to the essay question.

Hopefully you know what you're talking about in your essay, but that doesn't mean the reader will be able to grasp this automatically. You don't want to assume that your tutor is a mind reader. Instead, you want to make your ideas super clear with EXPLANATION.

Let's go back to our example. The POINT was that *there are numerous benefits to organisations of taking a bottom-up approach to strategy*. We've followed it up with our EVIDENCE – references and statistics showing that employee engagement and innovation are improved with this approach. Then we want to EXPLAIN ourselves. Here we might define and describe what a bottom-up approach to strategy is – which is where strategic decisions are not just made by leaders of an organisation. Ideas are taken from the bottom up – from the lower-level employees who are involved in everyday activity and who might be closer to the end users.

Then we would want to EXPLAIN our findings from the EVIDENCE. The EVIDENCE said that employee engagement could be increased by a bottom-up approach – so let's explain the nuts and bolts of how that happens. The same with innovation – why and how is innovation improved with a bottom-up approach? You should make it super clear with EXPLANATION.

LINK

The last part of PEEL is LINK. This is where you round out your paragraph. A lot of tutors say that LINK means linking to the next paragraph. This is sometimes the right answer, but it might be more appropriate to finish your paragraph by linking your idea back to the question, to really drive home each paragraph's partial answer to the question before you move onto the next one.

Let's look at two options for our example about the most effective approach to business strategy.

OPTION 1: LINK back to the question by summarising the overarching benefits of a bottom-up approach, recommending that organisations should integrate this approach to harness the full potential of its workforce.

OPTION 2: LINK to the next paragraph by summarising the benefits of a bottom-up approach but then explaining that this approach may not be effective for all organisations, where a top-down approach may be more appropriate. This is a great sentence for a few reasons. It demonstrates critical

thinking by showing a different perspective. And it signposts to the reader that the next paragraph is going to move the essay forward by talking about the situations or types of organisations where a bottom-up approach is less effective.

Flexibility with the PEEL method

The PEEL method can sometimes be a little prescriptive. It's not the perfect model or structure for every single paragraph in every single essay so I recommend flexibility.

1. You might want to switch up what you do with your LINK sentence or sentences. Sometimes linking to the next paragraph and sometimes linking back to the question. I would actually argue that the latter is more important. I would rather you always LINK back to the question – including those key words from the question and guidance to drive the relevance of each paragraph home to the reader. Linking to the next paragraph is less important as long as the ideas of the next paragraph flows.
2. You might want to switch around EXPLAIN and EVIDENCE. In this example about business strategy, you could make your POINT about there being numerous benefits to the bottom-up approach, then EXPLAIN what the bottom-up approach is. Then include EVIDENCE backing up your claims of the benefits then go back to EXPLAINING the findings from the evidence.
3. The standard PEEL framework does not include another important E – EVALUATION. This is where you test the strength and value of the EVIDENCE, by including counter EVIDENCE and other perspectives where necessary. Including EVALUATION will depend on your essay question – if you're expected to include analysis and critical thinking then you will want to weave your EVALUATION into your paragraphs. For this business strategy example, the EVALUATION part would be including the perspective that it's not as simple as saying that all organisations should adopt a bottom-up approach. Instead, there are different contexts and situations which make the approach more or less relevant.

Recommended approach for the PEEL method

Here's how I recommend incorporating the PEEL method to make your paragraphs more clear and powerful – so you can achieve higher marks.

1. Make your first sentence of each paragraph SUPER clear. It needs to explain the main argument/idea of the paragraph
2. Always LINK back to the question in the final sentence or sentences of your paragraph – using the keywords from the question and guidance
3. If you want to, add in a LINK to the next paragraph as your final sentence, but you may be able to incorporate that into your next paragraph in the POINT. E.g. *However, the bottom-up approach may not be relevant for all organisations.*
4. Your other sentences in your paragraph need to include EVIDENCE, EXPLANATION and EVALUATION (where relevant) but this can be in any order as long as it makes sense!

Summary

So there we have it, a breakdown of the four elements of the PEEL method with a handy example to help you apply it to your own subject. The PEEL method can be a little confusing so be sure to take my advice on how to get the most benefit of this method while being flexible to make it work for your specific essays.

Vocabulary

序号	单词	中文释义	例句
1.	perspective	观点, 视角	A critical essay should consider the issue from multiple perspectives before reaching a conclusion. (一篇批判性文章应在得出结论前从多个 视角 考虑问题。)
2.	integrate	整合, 使成为一体	Successful companies integrate sustainability goals into their core business strategy . (成功的公司将可持续发展目标 整合 到其核心业务 策略 中。)
3.	incorporate	包含, 纳入, 吸收	The revised model incorporates feedback from end users to improve its usability. (修订后的模型 吸纳 了 最终用户 的反馈, 以提升其易用性。)
4.	strategy	策略, 战略	The government's economic strategy focuses on stimulating innovation and domestic demand. (政府的经济 战略 侧重于刺激创新和内需。)
5.	splurge	杂乱无章地挥洒/写出	A well-argued paper is not a collection of thoughts splurged onto the page; it requires careful structuring. (一篇论证充分的论文不是将想法随意 挥洒 在纸上, 它需要精心构思结构。)
6.	craft (v.)	精心构思, 精心制作	Historians must craft their narratives based on a rigorous analysis of primary sources. (历史学家必须在对原始资料进行严谨分析的基础上 精心构建 其叙述。)
7.	variation	变体, 变化形式	The researcher proposed a variation of the standard experimental protocol to account for new variables. (研究者提出了标准实验方案的一个 变体 , 以将新的变量考虑在内。)
8.	bottom-up approach	自下而上的方法(指由基层意见或数据形成决策)	A bottom-up approach to urban planning often leads to solutions that are more responsive to community needs. (自下而上的城市规划方法通常能产生更贴合社区需求的解决方案。)
9.	top-down approach	自上而下的方法(指由高层制定决策)	In a crisis, a centralized, top-down approach may be necessary for swift and coordinated action. (在危机中, 集中的、自上而下的方法对于迅速、协调一致的行动可能是必要的。)
10.	put forward	提出(论点、	The scientist put forward a groundbreaking

		建议等)	hypothesis that challenged the prevailing theory. (这位科学家提出了一个挑战主流理论的突破性假说。)
11.	be grounded in	基于, 以...为基础	Effective policy recommendations must be grounded in solid empirical evidence. (有效的政策建议必须 基于 扎实的经验证据。)
12.	solid	扎实的, 可靠的, 有根据的	The argument lacks solid foundation, as it relies heavily on anecdotal rather than statistical data. (该论点缺乏 扎实的 基础, 因为它严重依赖轶事而非统计数据。)
13.	referencing	引用, 参考文献标注	Proper referencing is essential in academic writing to acknowledge sources and avoid plagiarism. (规范的 引用 在学术写作中至关重要, 用以注明出处并避免剽窃。)
14.	pull... out of your butt (俚语, 非正式)	凭空捏造, 胡诌 (文中用于强调论点需有依据, 而非杜撰)	(正式写作中应避免使用该俚语, 其概念可用 fabricate 或 baseless assertion 代替) Serious scholars cannot fabricate their data; their claims must be verifiable. (严肃的学者不能 捏造 数据; 其主张必须可验证。)
15.	end users	最终用户, 终端用户	The software's design prioritizes the experience of the end users , ensuring it is intuitive and efficient. (该软件的设计优先考虑 最终用户 的体验, 确保其直观高效。)
16.	nuts and bolts	基本要素, 具体细节	To understand the economic model, one must first grasp the nuts and bolts of supply and demand. (要理解这个经济模型, 必须首先掌握供需的 基本要素 。)
17.	round out	完成, 使圆满	The final chapter rounds out the book by synthesizing the key arguments and suggesting areas for future research. (最后一章通过综合关键论点并提出未来研究领域, 圆满地结束了 全书。)
18.	drive home	阐明, 使充分理解	The speaker used compelling statistics to drive home the urgency of addressing climate change. (演讲者用令人信服的统计数据 阐明了 应对气候变化的紧迫性。)
19.	overarching	总体的, 支配一切的	The overarching goal of the peace talks is to establish a lasting ceasefire and begin political negotiations. (和谈的 总体 目标是建立持久停火并开始政治谈判。)
20.	harness	利用, 驾驭	New technologies allow us to harness solar energy more efficiently than ever before. (新技术使我们能够比以往更有效地 利用 太阳能。)
21.	signposts (v.)	为...指明方向, 提示 (读者)	A clear introduction signposts the main arguments that will be developed in the essay. (一个清晰的引言会 提示 将在文中展开的主要论点。)

22.	prescriptive	规定性的, 死板的	The guide offers suggestions rather than prescriptive rules, allowing for flexibility in application. (该指南提供的是建议而非 死板 的规定, 允许应用上的灵活性。)
23.	switch up	改变, 变换 (非正式, 与 switch around 近义)	To maintain reader engagement, writers are advised to switch up their sentence structure. (为保持读者的阅读兴趣, 建议作者 变换 句式结构。)
24.	switch around	调换顺序	You can switch around the sections on methodology and literature review if it improves the logical flow. (如果能使逻辑更流畅, 你可以 调换 方法论和文献综述部分的顺序。)
25.	back up	支持, 证实	Always back up your claims with data or citations from authoritative sources. (务必用数据或权威来源的引文来 支持 你的主张。)
26.	weave into	融入, 交织进	A skilled writer weaves counterarguments into the text to demonstrate critical thinking. (娴熟的作者会将反面论点 融入 文中, 以展示批判性思维。)

Exercise

I Reading Comprehension

- According to the article, what is the primary function of the POINT sentence?
 - To provide detailed evidence
 - To introduce a surprising twist
 - To clearly state the paragraph's main idea
 - To link to the next paragraph
- The author suggests that the LINK sentence is most importantly used to:
 - Make the paragraph longer
 - Connect the paragraph's idea back to the essay question
 - Introduce a completely new topic
 - List all the evidence again
- What is the purpose of the EXPLANATION component in a PEEL paragraph?
 - To list more evidence
 - To assume the reader already understands everything
 - To make the ideas clear and show the relevance of the evidence
 - To conclude the entire essay
- According to the article, the PEEL method is:
 - A rigid rule that must be followed exactly for every paragraph
 - Only useful for writing introductions
 - A flexible framework that can be adapted
 - No longer recommended for academic writing

II Please fill in each blank with the most appropriate word or phrase

integrate, overarching, harness, solid, prescriptive, end users, bottom-up approach, signposts, perspective, splurged

1. The report's introduction clearly _____ the structure of the argument, guiding the reader through the subsequent analysis.
2. Unlike a rigid and _____ model, our framework is designed to be adaptable to different cultural contexts.
3. A successful product manager must always consider the needs and experiences of the _____ to ensure market adoption.
4. The study's conclusions are not convincing because they lack a _____ foundation in empirical data.
5. The _____ theme of the conference was how to _____ artificial intelligence to drive sustainable development.

III Circle the most suitable choice to replace the underlined word.

6. The researcher proposed a new theoretical model to explain the unexpected results.
A. crafted
B. put forward
C. incorporated
D. backed up
7. To make your argument persuasive, you must include relevant examples and statistical evidence.
A. integrate
B. incorporate
C. harness
D. splurge
8. The final chapter aims to complete the book by offering a forward-looking conclusion.
A. drive home
B. round out
C. switch up
D. weave into
9. It is essential for policymakers to understand the fundamental details of the economic system they are trying to reform.
A. overarching goals
B. nuts and bolts
C. end users
D. bottom-up approach
10. The author skillfully incorporates historical anecdotes into the narrative to illustrate her point more vividly.
A. pulls ... out of her butt
B. weaves ... into
C. signs ... into
D. backs ... up

IV Translation.

1. 一篇强有力的学术论文需要**精心构建**，而非将想法**杂乱地堆砌**在页面上；它必须**融入**清晰的路标来引导读者。（**crafted, splurged, incorporate, signposts**）
2. 使用 PEEL 方法时，你的**观点必须基于扎实的**证据，并且你需要**阐明**这些证据如何支持你的论点。（**perspective, grounded in solid, drive home**）
3. 一个有效的段落通常以明确的**观点**开始，然后**整合**证据与解释，最后通过**链接**回问题来**完成**论证。（**point, integrate, link, round out**）
4. While the PEEL method provides a useful structure, a **prescriptive** approach is not always best. Writers should feel free to **switch around** the order of Explanation and Evidence, or **weave critical evaluation into** their paragraphs to demonstrate a deeper **perspective**.
5. The **overarching** goal of a well-crafted paragraph is to **drive home** a partial answer to the essay question. This involves **harnessing** evidence to support your point and ensuring the content is relevant to the **end users** of your essay—typically, your assessor.